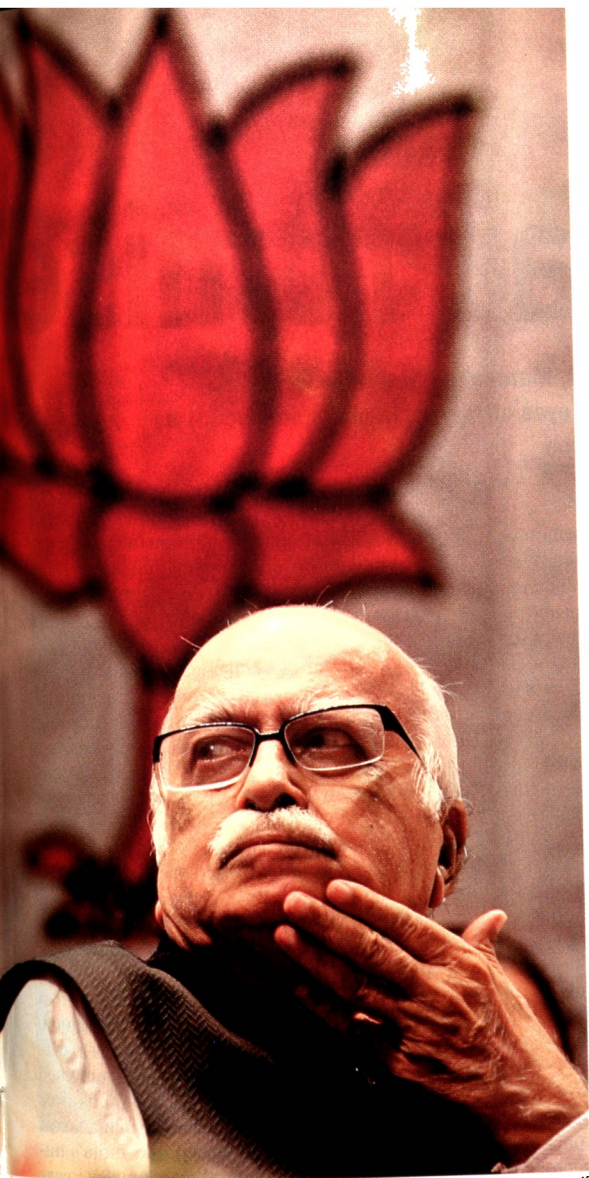




Caught in the Act

The Saffron party's wavering morality index

Tehelka

In 2001, BJP president Bangaru Laxman was caught-on-camera accepting Rs 1 lakh from representatives of a fictitious weapon firm. Laxman was asked to resign soon after.

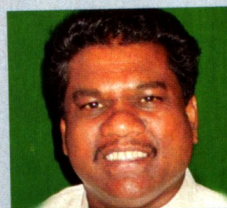


Operation Duryodhan

In 2005, MPs were caught-on-camera taking cash for asking questions in Parliament. Seven of these 11 MPs were from the BJP, including Suresh Chandel, and were expelled from Parliament.

Operation Chakravayuh

Another sting in 2005 exposed MPs soliciting a cut while allotting MPLAD projects. Three of the six accused were from the BJP, including Fagan Kulaste, but he was suspended only for a week.



Notegate

During the trust vote, three BJP MPs, Kulaste, Ashok Argal and Mahavir Bhagora, walked into the House with bags of money claiming that the UPA had tried to buy their votes for Rs 3 crore each.

general secretary. Advani knows all too well that the NDA—or for that matter the UPA too—is in no position to form the next government on its own. It will need the help of UNPA allies. But a resurgent Mayawati with prime ministerial ambitions has already made inroads on that turf, with the TRS, the TDP, the AGP and the JD(S) all declaring their support for her candidature. This was essentially Advani's Plan B and now it seems to be drifting away. Not only that, the Congress seems to have stolen the thunder in Uttar Pradesh with its alliance with the Samajwadi Party while Mayawati has worked a new Jat-Dalit combine with Ajit Singh's Rashtriya Lok Dal. The BJP is left on its own to battle these two new combinations.

Both the BJP and the Congress see the next set

of state polls as the run up to the general elections. In four of these, it is a straight fight between the two. Currently, the BJP is in power in three of these four. Losing any of these, despite the anti-incumbency factor could further damage cadre morale. The BJP is hoping to turn Notegate (the bribery scam) into a potent election issue.

The party Advani presides over is a pale imitation of the BJP of the 1980s. Unfortunately, the stakes now are much higher for him personally than they were over two decades ago. Advani laughed at the prime minister's suggestion to get new astrologers but the next few months could be the most crucial ones in his entire career. For that he needs the party behind him, not divided and crossing over to the other side. ■

STOCKTAKING:

L.K. Advani's most crucial battle is yet to come